HOW INDIA MADE HISTORY

THE INDIAN MEN'S BADMINTON TEAM WON GLORY BY CLINCHING THE THOMAS CUP FOR THE FIRST TIME. WHAT WENT INTO THE BIG WIN AND WHERE DO WE GO FROM HERE?

By Suhani Singh with Amarnath K. Menon and Ajay Sukumaran



DEADLY DOUBLE Satwiksairaj Rankireddy (left) and Chirag Shetty celebrate their win

Photographs by GETTY IMAGES

ON

SUNDAY, MAY 15, A cricket-obsessed nation found itself in awe of its shuttlers. Lakshya Sen was sprawled on the court, relieved, having come from a game down to defeat 2020 Olympics bronze medallist Anthony Sinisuka Ginting. Chirag Shetty took off his shirt to celebrate his and partner Satwiksairaj Rankireddy's victory, which saw them save four match points against doubles luminaries Mohammad Ahsan and Kevin Sanjaya Sukamuljo. The otherwise calm Kidambi Srikanth screamed and dropped his racquet after defeating Jonathan Christie. Trouncing 14-time champions Indonesia, India won the Thomas Cup, the world men's team championship in badminton. Think of it as similar to the Indian cricket team defeating Australia in the World Cup finals. Or, as the chief coach of the national badminton team, Pullela Gopichand, puts it—like the Kapil Dev-led team beating the mighty West Indies in